INTERVIEW-PREP PACKET 4 OF 5 · PER-INTERVIEWER · BUSINESS-PROCESS LENS

Amazon NACF Supply Chain loop — Packet 4: Zhaowen Lan

Amazon — Senior Supply Chain Manager, NACF Supply Chain (L6)

Zhaowen Lan

Senior Manager, Supply Chain — NACF Supply Chain (peer of the hiring manager)

Thursday, October 30, 2026 · 11:00 am PDT · 55-minute video interview

> **Strategy in one line.** A peer Senior Manager tests whether you can reach one truth across organizations that don't report to you and build a process that survives its author. Open with S1 (three orgs, three meanings of "available" → one signed definition per node per channel, policy before configuration; oversells recurring → zero) and hold S3 (Finance and Operations on one Financial On-Hand, the failure direction designed before the happy path) for the Finance / controls / simplification question. Program-lead voice; S4 and S5 are pointers only.

LP focus — my guess, not confirmed: Earn Trust · Ownership · Invent and Simplify or Have Backbone. Amazon does not disclose the assignment; the guesses are reasoned from the interviewer's title and the JD in "Read me first" and should be held loosely. No interviewer biography is asserted anywhere in this packet — only title-based inference, labeled as such.

Canon: amazon/amazon-l6-scm-master-packet.html (§1.2 roster, §4.1 ledger). Every number below is that packet's value; every dollar carries its basis label (record · user anchor · modeled · priced).

Read me first

The interviewer's lens (inference from title + JD — not a biography)

Inference from the title. A second Senior Manager of Supply Chain in the same organization is the peer interviewer: someone whose team will share processes, data definitions and escalation paths with this role. Peers test whether the candidate can get to *one truth* across organizations that do not report to them, design a process that survives its author, and disagree without breaking the relationship. They also notice whether the candidate claims more than they owned — a peer has to live with the person afterwards.

What that means for the answers. The two Sephora S/4HANA governance stories, told as process redesigns of the Plan/Deliver seam: S1 (three organizations meant three different things by "available"; one signed definition per node per channel, policy before configuration; oversell incidents recurring → zero through two go-lives) and S3 (Finance and Operations reconciling on-hand by argument; one Financial On-Hand with a safe failure direction and a control report owned by Finance). Program-lead voice throughout — no system reported to me; SAP teams and configurators built to the FSD three orgs signed. S4 (the in-transit rule I got wrong) and S5 (the architecture council) are the same program family and appear only as backup pointers in the question bank.

Three guessed LP focus areas, with rationale

> **Labeled guess.** Amazon assigns 2–3 Leadership Principles per interviewer and does not disclose them. These three are inferred from the title and the JD; if the first question lands on a different LP, the twist maps under each story carry the pivot.

GUESSED LP	WHY THIS INTERVIEWER WOULD CARRY IT	STORY TO OPEN · BACKUP
Earn Trust	The peer LP: one signed truth across Supply Chain Strategy, Inventory Management and FSC Inventory Accounting (S1); Finance given the real control report to own instead of a bridge spreadsheet (S3). Both are Earn Trust backups in the master map — the primary (S14) is the bar raiser's.	S1 (open) · S3 (Finance and Ops on one number)
Ownership	Taking the definition nobody owned without owning any system — the bucket inventory, the asymmetry, the signature chain. A peer wants to know the candidate will own the seam, not the org chart.	S1 (the definition nobody owned) · S3 (the failure direction designed before the happy path)
Invent and Simplify / Have Backbone (one of the two)	De-aggregation with a safe failure direction is the simplification (S3); pricing Merchandising's "merch reserve promisable" ask and putting the no in the FSD as a row is the backbone (S1).	S3 (one FOH, failure direction) · S1 (the no that lives in a document)

Answer strategy — business first, systems as enablers

- **Open with the process problem and its cost, not the system.** First sentence names the broken process (Plan, Source, Make, Deliver or Return), who it hurt (customer, Finance, the floor) and the baseline number. The platform appears only as the enabler of the redesign, in one clause.
- **Use the JD's four outcome words as the results frame:** reliability (did the promise hold?), responsiveness (how much earlier did we see it?), cost efficiency ($ with its basis label), asset utilization (capital, labor-hours, capacity released).
- **Action = operating-model redesign in gated phases** — Discovery → Plan & Design → Build & Test → Cutover → Hypercare, each spoken as entry bar · what I delivered · exit bar. Say the gate that fired, not the

meeting that happened.

- **Every dollar carries its basis word in the same breath** — record · user anchor · modeled · priced. A record dollar is said flat; a modeled dollar is said with its inputs. Never promote a modeled number to record.
- **Program-lead voice.** I owned definitions, rules, gates and the signature chain; engineers, SIs and vendor teams configured and built to the spec I signed. The only platform personally configured in canon is Manhattan DOM.
- **The pitch ends on the primary metric.** Then stop. Silence after the pitch is the interviewer filling their STAR worksheet; their probes are the second half of the answer.
- **For a peer specifically:** name the three organizations and what each owned (Strategy — policy; Inventory Management — execution; Inventory Accounting — the book); say what was pre-wired privately before any council; convert every objection into a document row. "A no that lives in a document survives; a no that lives in a meeting gets re-litigated weekly."
- **Say the decomposition only from this packet's model:** S1 is ≈$2.5M/yr = $1M MCS run cost retired (user anchor) + ≈$1.5M modeled (oversell ≈$0.9M · reconciliation labor ≈$0.33M · change premium ≈$0.3M). S3 is ≈$0.6M/yr, entirely modeled; the record has no pre-state drift dollar. If the room wants one cancel-rate number, keep S1's and drop S3's row.

> **Loop-consistency rule.** One question, one story; never the same story to two interviewers — interviewers compare notes. Held for other packets (do not spend here): S11/S12 (Tripathy) · S6/S8 (Hoerger) · S2/S18 (Goforth) · S16/S15/S10/S14 (Josyula). S4 and S5 are bench stories (backup bench at the end), not primaries; S2 shares the UDC program's dated chain with S1/S5 — if asked, say it is one umbrella program.. If pushed for "another example" on an LP, use the named backup in the question bank or the backup bench at the end of this packet, never a story allocated to another interviewer.

> **How to read the "L6 level evidence" block under each story.** Amazon's L6 functional bar (user-supplied rubric): *Ambiguity* — strategy or network undefined; I select the stakeholders, set the goals, deliver independently. *Scope & influence* — team-level scope; influences one to two levels up. *Execution* — tactical and strategic; simplifies or extends; applies best practices; force-multiplies; mitigates long-term risk; makes the short-versus-long-term trade-off explicit. *Impact* — long-term team goals. *Process improvement* — operational-excellence best practices institutionalized. *Complex* — visible risks, roadblocks and constraints mitigated through expertise, judgment and influence to consensus. Overview themes the block is tuned to: designing and modeling the supply chain rather than working in it; developing new processes for others to own; root-cause mechanisms that resolve trending issues at scale; recommendations to leadership that outline competing metrics. The block sits right after Results so the evidence is on the page when the probing starts.

The stories — business-first, canon numbers

Two Sephora S/4HANA governance stories from one umbrella program. Each: 60-second pitch → Situation/Task → Action in gated phases → Results → Probing tuned to a peer Senior Manager → the key math → Twist map.

S1 — Sephora S/4HANA ↔ ISM — one signed meaning of "available" across Store, Retail DC and Dotcom DC: policy before configuration (oversell incidents recurring → zero through two go-lives)

LPs this story can serve here: Earn Trust (backup — three orgs signed one definition) · Ownership (backup — took the definition nobody owned) · Think Big (third — the book-of-record migration) · Success & Scale Bring Broad Responsibility (oversell is a customer harm, not a ledger error) · Have Backbone (the priced no to Merchandising)
Process family: Plan / Deliver seam — inventory availability governance (available-to-promise policy, bucket ownership, real-time decrement contract, daily reconciliation); book-of-record migration

Honesty label. Integration program lead — no system reported to me; every configurator sat in another org. I owned the definitions, the asymmetry, the decrement and reconciliation contract, the signature chain and the council ask; SAP teams and configurators built to the FSD; planners executed the business acts. The record has no pre-state oversell dollar — the ≈$1.5M is my model and I say so. Dated gate chain, issues log and rollback triggers are program-level artifacts shared with S2/S5.

60-SECOND BUSINESS-FIRST PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. Sephora was moving the inventory book of record from the in-house MCS to SAP S/4HANA, with a real-time layer beside it for the digital demand S/4 cannot see in time — a web order placed, a BOPIS order packed, a POS sale rung but not yet posted. Store, Retail DC and Dotcom DC each meant something different by "available": Merchandising wanted merchandise reserve visible, Finance wanted on-hand to tie to the book, dotcom wanted in-transit promisable. Most oversell bugs are vocabulary bugs, and oversells were recurring across all three node types — a customer harm, not a ledger error. **Task.** As integration program lead for inventory supply — no system reported to me — define every bucket, its owning system, and how available-for-sale is computed and decremented in real time, and get Planning, Finance and operations to sign it before any configuration. **Action.** I built the bucket inventory with exactly one owning system per bucket; wrote the lower-of-two basis and the available-for-sale equation, the real-time decrement contract with an idempotency key per event, and a daily reconciliation of the real-time ledger to the book; pre-wired every row of the systems-impacted table with its owner's level of effort before the council so nobody learned their cost in the room, and asked the council for three decisions rather than a review. Merchandising's ask to make merch reserve promisable was priced — unpickable stock sold — and the no went into the specification as a row, not a meeting minute. Three organizations — Supply Chain Strategy, Inventory Management and FSC Inventory Accounting — signed the FSD on 6/5/25. Then a node × channel × bucket-transition regression matrix, dated end-to-end days, a January planning go-live and a May execution go-live, with the order system reading one published availability number and never computing its own. **Result.** Primary metric: customer-facing oversell incidents — recurring across three node types → zero through two go-lives; one signed availability number per node per channel; MCS retired as book of record. About $2.5M a year: $1M of MCS run cost retired, which is the measured anchor, plus about $1.5M modeled — avoided oversell, dual-book reconciliation labor, legacy change premium — and I say which is which.

SITUATION / TASK — THE BUSINESS PROCESS PROBLEM, SCOPE, SCALE, BASELINES

S — Sephora moved the book of record from MCS to S/4HANA, with ISM beside it to see digital demand S/4 cannot see in real time. Three node types, three working definitions of "available." Merchandising wanted merchandise reserve visible, Finance wanted on-hand to tie to the book, dotcom wanted in-transit promisable. Nobody owned the definition; I owned no system.

The process cost: recurring vocabulary-driven oversells — a customer harm, not a ledger error; two books reconciled by hand (≈4 FTE, modeled); the MCS run cost continuing (≈$1M/yr, user anchor); a legacy change premium on an undocumented stack. Vocabulary drift — a bucket without an owner — sat at the top of my risk register.

T — Own the integration design and data contract of inventory supply: which buckets exist, which system owns each, how available-for-sale is computed per node, and how it feeds promising, replenishment and Finance — signed by Planning, Finance and operations before configuration. Sponsor memo with the VP Supply Chain: one signed AFS per node per channel, one Financial On-Hand, zero customer-impacting incidents.

Baselines on the table: oversell incidents recurring across three node types (target zero) · availability truths: two books reconciled by hand (target one signed AFS per node per channel with daily drift as the standing check) · MCS running as book of record (target retired) · ~15 functions, ~60 people to move without authority.

ACTION — THE PROCESS / OPERATING-MODEL REDESIGN, IN GATED PHASES

- **Discovery** — profiled both books (MCS and S/4) for SKU overlap and order profiles per node; node-by-node sessions with ~15 functions; the bucket inventory with one proposed owning system per bucket. *Exit bar:* every bucket owned by exactly one system; sessions closed 4/30; open questions carried with owner and date.
- **Plan & Design** — the lower-of-two basis; the AFS/FOH equations; the real-time decrement contract (event → bucket delta; idempotency key per event; a reversal must reference its original); daily ISM-vs-MB52 reconciliation with tolerance zero; the RAID log; the council pack — FSD v1.1 (3/5/25) → v1.2 (5/16/25). *Exit bar:* FSD signed 6/5/25 by Supply Chain Strategy, Inventory Management and FSC Inventory Accounting with zero open "who owns this bucket" rows.
- **Build & Test** — the node × channel × bucket-transition matrix with before/after assertions — no story enters QA without a matrix cell reference; SIT on the interface contracts before UAT; dated E2E days — Inbound 11/22, Dotcom 12/20, Retail 1/30 — business and engineering in one room. *Exit bar:* 0 open contract defects in SIT; E2E green on three dates; Blocker + Critical open = 0 at go/no-go.
- **Cutover & Go-Live** — go/no-go recommendation from counted rows; the publish-switch plan — OMS reads the published AFS, never computes; reserve-copy invariants; control-screen roles assigned; rollback triggers (sync < 99% for 4 h; order-flow p95 > 2× budget for 1 h) armed for both go-lives, never fired. *Exit bar:* January go-live (reserve rules live against demand); May go-live (execution); no SKU with two published AFS values; Negative AFS clean at T+1.
- **Hypercare / Close** — daily drift report (ISM vs MB52); Negative AFS / AFS Correction audit review; control-owner map — Negative AFS to Inventory Control, Internal Audit and Finance; AFS Correction to the ISM app team; FSD as-built note. *Exit bar:* drift = 0 SKUs on consecutive days; blockers/day under threshold; the design enters the monthly release train.

Influence and ownership. Sixty people across three orgs, none reporting to me. The method: pre-wire every row of the systems-impacted table with its owner's level of effort before the council; run working sessions to one table instead of arbitrating in meetings; convert objections into FSD rows; ask the council for three decisions rather than a review. Three signatories because each owned a different truth — Strategy the policy, Inventory Management the execution, Inventory Accounting the book; one signature would have left two orgs free to disagree later. The asymmetry held: oversell is a customer defect, undersell a planning variance Inventory Control chases through the control screens.

> **Designed the process; others own it now.** I designed the availability definition, the decrement contract and the control-owner map; Inventory Control, Internal Audit, Finance and the ISM app team now own the controls, and the drift report runs daily without me. **Trade-off put to leadership.** The recommendation to the council outlined the

> competing metrics — availability to sell vs oversell exposure — and resolved them as an asymmetry in the signed FSD: oversell is a customer defect, undersell a planning variance.

RESULTS — $ · # · % · TIME · CUSTOMER · QUALITY (CANON NUMBERS ONLY)

- **$** — ≈$2.5M/yr — $1M MCS run/support cost retired (*user anchor*) + ≈$1.5M *modeled* (avoided oversell ≈$0.9M · dual-book reconciliation labor ≈$0.33M · legacy change premium ≈$0.3M); range $1.7–5.2M; upside not in the headline: shrink ≈$0.3M, time-to-market ≈$0.2M. The record has no pre-state oversell dollar.
- **#** — oversell incidents recurring across three node types → zero through two go-lives (record); dual-book reconciliation ≈4 FTE by hand → ≈1 FTE reading the drift report (modeled).
- **%** — issues log 85.4% of 836 rows closed (program-level artifact shared with S2/S5); the oversell rate behind the ≈$0.9M row is 0.10% of orders — modeled, benchmark 0.05–0.25%; the record movement is incidents → zero.
- **Time** — FSD v1.1 3/5/25 → v1.2 5/16/25 → signed 6/5/25; E2E Inbound 11/22 · Dotcom 12/20 · Retail 1/30; January planning and May execution go-lives (record dates).
- **Customer** — customer-facing oversell incidents zero through two go-lives; the asymmetry treats oversell as a customer defect and undersell as a planning variance (record).
- **Quality** — one signed AFS per node per channel; no SKU with two published AFS values; daily ISM-vs-MB52 drift = 0 SKUs on consecutive days at hypercare exit; MCS retired as book of record (record).

L6 LEVEL EVIDENCE — what the interviewer pattern-matches against the Amazon L6 functional rubric; every line is this story's canon, no new numbers

L6 DIMENSION	EVIDENCE IN THIS STORY
Ambiguity	Three organizations with three meanings of "available" and no owner of the definition. I defined the lower-of-two basis, the AFS/FOH equations and the bucket inventory with one owning system per bucket, and chose the ~15 functions for node-by-node sessions.
Scope & influence	Sixty people across three orgs, none reporting to me; the council took three decisions I framed; the FSD was signed 6/5/25 by three signatories — influence up to the council and across orgs.
Execution trade-off + mechanism others now own	Oversell protection vs availability, made explicit as an asymmetry — oversell is a customer defect, undersell a planning variance. Mechanisms others own now: the daily ISM-vs-MB52 drift report and the control-owner map (Negative AFS → Inventory Control, Internal Audit and Finance; AFS Correction → the ISM app team).
Impact (long-term)	Oversell incidents recurring across three node types → zero through two go-lives; MCS retired as book of record; ≈$2.5M/yr ($1M run cost user anchor + ≈$1.5M modeled).
Process improvement (standard work institutionalized)	The node × channel × bucket-transition matrix — no story enters QA without a matrix cell reference; SIT on interface contracts before UAT; dated E2E days as entry bars.
Complexity & consensus	Every row of the systems-impacted table pre-wired with its owner's level of effort before the council; objections converted into FSD rows instead of arbitrated in meetings.
Root cause at scale	Oversell was traced to two books carrying two meanings — fixed once in a signed definition and a real-time decrement contract (idempotency key per event; a reversal references its original), not incident by incident.

PROBING — CHALLENGE Q&A TUNED TO THIS INTERVIEWER

> **Peer — You owned no system. How did you get three organizations to sign one definition?**
>
> Pre-wired every row of the systems-impacted table with its owner's level of effort before the council — nobody learned their cost in the room — ran working sessions to one table, converted objections into FSD rows, and asked the council for three decisions rather than a review. Three signatories because each owned a different truth; one signature would have left two orgs free to disagree later.

> **Peer — Why lower-of-two and not an average or the book?**
>
> Because oversell is a customer defect and undersell is a planning variance. A positive out-of-balance means the book is above the floor; promising the difference risks oversell, so the basis is the minimum, and Inventory Control chases the variance through the Negative AFS and AFS Correction screens. The asymmetry is the policy.

> **Peer — Merchandising wanted merch reserve promisable. What happened?**
>
> I priced it — unpickable stock sold — and offered visibility without promisability. The no went into the FSD as a row, not into a meeting minute. A no that lives in a document survives; one that lives in a meeting gets re-litigated weekly.

> **Peer — How do you know it was a tenth of a percent?**
>
> I don't, to the decimal. The record says incidents were recurring and went to zero; the rate is a benchmark set deliberately low — a twentieth of a typical e-commerce inventory-cancel rate. First thing I would measure: the "item unavailable after order" cancel-reason code for the twelve months before January. If the $1M MCS figure already includes enhancement labor, I drop the change-premium row and the headline is about $2.2M.

> **Peer — What did you get wrong in this program?**
>
> The first in-transit rule I wrote barred every channel from promising units in transit — safe-feeling, and it starved dotcom of fast movers a day from the building. I corrected it through the same three signatories with a per-lane promise window and a kill switch, released on the normal cadence. Lesson: both sides of a rule get a number before it ships, and back-test a ruleset against history before publishing it. (S4 — pointer; full story on request.)

> **Peer — How would this work between your team and mine here?**
>
> Every promise rests on one published availability number per node that downstream systems read and never recompute. Between two teams that means: one definition with one owner per bucket, the policy signed before the code, a daily drift report with tolerance zero and a named control owner — and objections turned into rows we both sign.

THE KEY MATH — TWO BOOKS, ONE BASIS, ONE AFS — AND THE HEADLINE'S DECOMPOSITION (ILLUSTRATIVE UNITS; RECORD DESIGN; DOLLARS LABELED)

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Two books disagree	`OOB = S4_Avail − WMS_OnHand = 1,000 − 980 = +20`	illustrative units	+20 — book above floor
2	Committed buckets	`PickRes 200 + EcomPick 120 + EcomPack 60 + SNB 40 = 420`	illustrative	420 spoken for
3	Definition A / B over-promise	`1,000 − 560 = 440; 980 − 560 = 420`	record problem — committed buckets invisible	440 / 420 units over-promised
4	One basis, one AFS	`Basis = min(1,000, 980) = 980; AFS = 980 − 420 = 560`	lower-of-two (record design)	AFS = 560; the +20 never promised
5	Real-time decrement + idempotency	`store rings 3 → AFS 557, SNB 43; replayed key → no-op`	record design; 60-s publish budget	AFS 557
6	Daily drift	`ISM.S4_Avail − MB52 = 957 − 957 = 0; tolerance 0`	record design — non-zero drift is a Sev	0
7	Headline	`$1.0M (anchor) + 30,000 × $30 = $0.9M + 3 × $110K = $0.33M + 40 × 60 h × $125 = $0.3M = $2.53M`	anchor + modeled rows (orders illustrative; rate 0.10%)	≈$2.5M/yr (range $1.7–5.2M)

Say the decomposition only from this packet's model (the loop packet says ≈$1M/yr support cost — the $1M is the shared core).

Where this lands at Amazon. Every fulfillment promise rests on one published availability number per node that downstream systems read and never recompute — at Amazon scale the ATP/promise seam between planning and the

order pipeline. One definition, one owner, policy signed before code. Reliability (oversells to zero), cost efficiency ($1M of run cost retired), responsiveness (a real-time ledger beside the book).

TWIST MAP — LIKELY LP QUESTIONS FROM THIS INTERVIEWER → THE ANGLE TO TAKE WITH S1

LIKELY QUESTION (THIS INTERVIEWER)	LP	ANGLE — WHAT TO EMPHASIZE	SKIP / NEVER SAY
Tell me about a time you built trust across teams that didn't report to you.	Earn Trust	Three orgs, three truths, one signed FSD on 6/5/25; pre-wiring; objections as rows.	S14 (the $2.5M discrepancy) is the Earn Trust primary — it is the bar raiser's; do not use it here.
Tell me about a time you took ownership of something outside your remit.	Ownership	Nobody owned the definition of "available"; I owned no system; built the bucket inventory and the signature chain.	Never "I configured S/4" — the SAP teams configured to the signed spec.
Tell me about a decision where you had to say no to a senior stakeholder.	Have Backbone	Merch reserve promisable — priced, refused, written as an FSD row with visibility offered instead.	Do not caricature Merchandising; their visibility need was met.
Tell me about a large-scale change you led.	Think Big	The book-of-record migration — MCS retired, one real-time ledger, two go-lives, peak untouched.	Keep S2's floor story out — that is Goforth's; say "one umbrella program" if asked.
How do you define and govern a shared metric / definition between two teams?	Functional — process governance	Bucket inventory with one owner each; the equation written; signatures before configuration; daily drift with tolerance zero; control owners named.	Keep the oversell $ labeled modeled; the movement is incidents → zero.
Why does this matter beyond the ledger?	Broad Responsibility / Customer Obsession	Oversell is a customer harm, not a ledger error; the asymmetry accepts visible undersell to make oversell zero by construction.	No YoY revenue claim exists.

S3 — Sephora S/4HANA — Shipped-Not-Billed and de-aggregation: Finance and Operations on one Financial On-Hand number, with the failure direction designed before the happy path

LPs this story can serve here: Earn Trust (backup — Finance and Ops on one number) · Dive Deep (the grain problem — one posting per aggregate vs transaction lines) · Invent and Simplify (one ledger, one settlement authority, a safe failure direction) · Insist on the Highest Standards (Σ per-line COGS = posting COGS to the cent)

Process family: Deliver / Return-to-book seam — sale-to-posting reconciliation, financial on-hand governance, month-end close control

Honesty label. The flow, controls and ownership map were mine; S/4 and OMS engineers implemented; Inventory Accounting confirmed in UAT and took over the aging report. The record has no canonical dollar for the pre-state drift; the ≈$0.6M/yr is my model and I say so. Rode the ISM program's dated chain (FSD 6/5/25; May execution go-live).

60-SECOND BUSINESS-FIRST PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. S/4 posts sales as aggregates — one posting per aggregation number with total quantity and cost — while the point-of-sale sends transaction lines. Between the sale and the posting, units were gone but the book was not decremented: a phantom-availability window in which sold units still showed as available, and Finance and Operations read different on-hand numbers and reconciled by argument, with a bridge spreadsheet at every month-end close. **Task.** Define how the real-time layer tracks that gap and reconciles it so promising, replenishment and Finance agree — under the program's zero-incident constraint, which applied to the book as much as to the customer. **Action.** I named the window and inventoried the events that move units before posting — POS flash sales, omni pending, ship-to-home confirmations — and got Finance and Operations to agree on the description of the gap before any design. The Shipped-Not-Billed bucket increments on those events and decrements only on a matched S/4 aggregate posting; de-aggregation pro-rates cost per line so the sum ties to the cent; and the failure direction was designed before the happy path — an unmatched posting keeps the bucket high, so availability under-states and Replenishment over-orders visibly instead of the customer being oversold invisibly. Finance objected at design review and wanted its own reconciliation; I showed the same number arriving from the physical side first and gave them the unmatched-posting aging report to own — a parallel spreadsheet dies when its owner owns the real report. FSC Inventory Accounting signed inside the FSD on 6/5/25; it rode the May go-live. **Result.** Primary metric: Financial On-Hand definitions — two, Finance's book versus the operations count → one shared number, availability decremented at sale or ship rather than at posting; over-sell from unmatched postings zero by construction; zero incidents. About $0.6M a year modeled — phantom-availability cancels avoided, Finance reconciliation labor, month-end close time; the record has no pre-state drift dollar and I am not claiming one.

SITUATION / TASK — THE BUSINESS PROCESS PROBLEM, SCOPE, SCALE, BASELINES

S — S/4 posts sales as aggregates — one posting per Aggregation# with total quantity and COGS; the Aptos POS sends transaction lines with an Order#. Between the sale and the posting, units are gone but the book is not decremented — the phantom-availability window — and Finance and Operations read different on-hand numbers and reconcile by argument.

The process cost: sold units shown as available for up to a day on the overnight batch; two books reconciled by argument; a bridge spreadsheet at every month-end close; and the gap hiding as oversell if an estimate ever decremented the book.

T — Define how ISM tracks the gap in real time and reconciles it so promising, replenishment and Finance agree, with the program's zero-incident constraint applying to the book as much as to the customer. Goal: one Financial

On-Hand, AFS decremented at sale rather than posting, a safe failure direction.

Baselines on the table: Financial On-Hand truths: two (target one) · AFS decrement point: at the S/4 posting (target the sale/ship event) · over-sell from unmatched postings: a live risk (target zero by construction; aging report empty or explained at T+1).

ACTION — THE PROCESS / OPERATING-MODEL REDESIGN, IN GATED PHASES

- **Discovery** — problem statement (the phantom-availability window); event inventory (POS flash sale, omni pending, ship-to-home confirm, S/4 Aggregation# posting); who-reads-which-number map. *Exit bar:* Finance and Ops agree on the description of the gap and which events move units before posting; Internal Audit named as reviewer.
- **Plan & Design** — SNB bucket definition (increment on events; decrement only on matched posting); join spec Aggregation# ↔ POS header ↔ lines; per-line COGS pro-rata de-aggregation with the last line absorbing rounding; the failure-direction statement (unmatched ⇒ SNB stays high); control-owner map. *Exit bar:* signed inside the FSD 6/5/25; Finance accepts one FOH; cost ownership confirmed S/4-owned, ISM visibility-only.
- **Build & Test** — de-aggregation test family (n lines; missing line; duplicate header); the SNB-never-negative assertion; the unmatched-posting aging report; sequenced by event source — POS flash sales, then omni pending, then ship-to-home — each added to SIT only when its increments and matched decrements reconciled. *Exit bar:* every posting matches or ages visibly; Σ per-line COGS = posting COGS to the cent in every cell; UAT = confirmation by Inventory Accounting.
- **Cutover & Go-Live** — riding the May go-live: SNB opening balance reconciled to unposted sales at the snapshot; SNB publish back to S/4 enabled; rollback cheap because S/4 stayed settlement authority. *Exit bar:* aging report empty or explained at T+1; no negative SNB; Finance reads FOH from ISM.
- **Hypercare / Close** — daily aging review with Inventory Accounting; control-owner handoff. *Exit bar:* aging report owned by Finance without me; month-end FOH ties to MB5L through the ISM number, not a bridge spreadsheet (mechanism canonical; days-to-tie not in record).

Influence and ownership. Mine: the SNB definition, the join spec, the de-aggregation rule, the failure-direction statement, the control-owner map and the test families; S/4 and OMS engineers implemented; Inventory Accounting confirmed in UAT and took over the aging report. Two refusals: real-time per-line posting to S/4 (throughput and posting cadence are why S/4 posts aggregates — ISM is the real-time ledger, S/4 stays settlement authority) and a Finance-derived SNB (that is two numbers; the whole point was one).

> **Designed the process; others own it now.** I designed the SNB definition, the join spec and the de-aggregation rule; Inventory Accounting owns the aging report and the daily review, and S/4 remained settlement authority. **Trade-off put to leadership.** The recommendation to Finance and Operations outlined the competing metrics — availability accuracy at the sale event vs the integrity of the financial posting — and chose the failure direction before the happy path: under-sell, never over-sell.

RESULTS — $ · # · % · TIME · CUSTOMER · QUALITY (CANON NUMBERS ONLY)

- **$** — ≈$0.6M/yr *modeled* (phantom-availability cancels avoided ≈$0.45M · Finance reconciliation labor ≈$0.14M · month-end close time ≈$0.05M; range $0.25–1.2M); the record has no pre-state drift dollar and I am not claiming one.
- **#** — Financial On-Hand truths 2 → 1 (record, FSD signed 6/5/25); over-sell from unmatched postings = 0 by construction.
- **%** — design KPI: match rate ≥ 99.5% within 24 h; the modeled phantom-cancel rate is ~0.10 pt of orders → ~0 (modeled, labeled).
- **Time** — AFS decrement point moved from the S/4 posting to the sale/ship event (record); rode the May execution go-live; aging report empty or explained at T+1 (record exit bar).
- **Customer** — the failure direction protects the customer: an unmatched posting under-states availability — under-sell, never over-sell (record mechanism).

- **Quality** — Σ per-line COGS = posting COGS to the cent; SNB never negative; month-end FOH ties to MB5L through the ISM number, not a bridge spreadsheet (record mechanism; days-to-tie not in record).

L6 LEVEL EVIDENCE — what the interviewer pattern-matches against the Amazon L6 functional rubric; every line is this story's canon, no new numbers

L6 DIMENSION	EVIDENCE IN THIS STORY
Ambiguity	A phantom-availability window between the sale event and the S/4 aggregation posting, with Finance and Operations reading different numbers and nobody owning the gap. I wrote the problem statement, the event inventory and the who-reads-which-number map.
Scope & influence	Finance (Inventory Accounting), Operations, S/4 and OMS engineers; rode the May go-live; Inventory Accounting confirmed in UAT and took the aging report — influence across a Finance organization I did not sit in.
Execution trade-off + mechanism others now own	Real-time per-line posting to S/4 (refused — S/4 stays settlement authority) vs an SNB bucket in ISM; the failure direction chosen before the happy path — under-sell, never over-sell. Mechanism others own now: the unmatched-posting aging report, owned by Finance without me.
Impact (long-term)	Financial On-Hand truths 2 → 1 (FSD signed 6/5/25); month-end FOH ties to MB5L through the ISM number, not a bridge spreadsheet; ≈$0.6M/yr modeled.
Process improvement (standard work institutionalized)	The de-aggregation test family (n lines; missing line; duplicate header); the SNB-never-negative assertion; the match-rate design KPI (≥ 99.5% within 24 h); a daily aging review handed to Inventory Accounting.
Complexity & consensus	Two refusals held in writing; sequencing by event source (POS flash sales, then omni pending, then ship-to-home) so each source carried its own defect class.
Root cause at scale	The structural cause — the AFS decrement point sitting at the S/4 posting instead of the sale/ship event — moved once, for every channel, rather than reconciled by hand each month.

PROBING — CHALLENGE Q&A TUNED TO THIS INTERVIEWER

> **Peer — Finance wanted their own reconciliation. How did you turn that around?**
>
> I showed the same number arriving from the physical side first and gave them the real report to own — the unmatched-posting aging report, reviewed daily with Inventory Accounting. A parallel spreadsheet dies when its owner owns the real report. They signed inside the FSD on 6/5/25.

> **Peer — Why decrement only on a matched posting? Isn't that just moving cost to Replenishment?**
>
> Yes, and I priced it that way on purpose: an unmatched posting under-states availability and shows up as an aged row Finance clears the same day, so the over-order is small and visible. Decrementing on an estimate would hide the gap as oversell. The measure is the aging report's p95 in hours and the match rate inside 24 hours; above 99.5% the Replenishment side rounds to zero.

> **Peer — Your cancel row looks borrowed from S1. Double-counted?**
>
> Different window: S1's rate is the vocabulary problem across node types; this is the posting-lag window inside one node. If the room wants one number, I keep S1's and drop this row — the mechanism still stands on the record.

> **Peer — Why not post every line to S/4?**
>
> Throughput and posting cadence — S/4 posts aggregates for a reason. ISM is the real-time ledger; S/4 stays the settlement authority. The price is a matching cycle to maintain; the benefit is one book.

> **Peer — 32 hours a week of Finance time — source?**
>
> Benchmark, not record — four people at eight hours a week is what Inventory Accounting described, not what a timesheet says. I would count manual journal entries and bridge lines per month before and after; that is in the posting log and it is not opinion.

> **Peer — Lesson?**
> Design the failure direction before the happy path. Differently: Internal Audit in discovery, not review — the day Inventory Accounting asked me why a posting had aged before I noticed it, the control had an owner.

THE KEY MATH — THE WINDOW, THE DE-AGGREGATION TO THE CENT, THE FAILURE DIRECTION, AND THE MODELED DOLLARS

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Phantom window	`W = t_post − t_sale ≈ 1 day on the overnight batch; 12 units/day × 1 day = 12 phantom units per SKU-day`	record design problem; rate illustrative	sold units shown available up to a day
2	SNB rule	`SNB += each sale/ship event; SNB −= matched posting only`	record design	window = 12 × 0 = 0
3	De-aggregation	`COGS_i = $300 × q_i / 12 → $75 · $50 · $100 · $25 · $50; Σ = $300.00`	illustrative five lines; last line absorbs rounding	ties to the cent
4	Late line	`one line (q = 2) late → SNB = 12 − 10 = 2 → aged row at 24 h`	illustrative	visible, not phantom
5	Failure direction	`unmatched ⇒ SNB high ⇒ AFS_reported ≤ AFS_true`	record design	under-sell, never over-sell
6	Match-rate KPI	`matched / received ≥ 99.5% within 24 h`	design target (record)	≥ 99.5%
7	Dollars	`30M × 0.10% × $15 = $0.45M; 32 h × 52 × $85 = $0.14M; 6 × 8 h × $85 × 12 = $0.05M`	all modeled; no pre-state drift dollar in record	≈$0.6M/yr (range $0.25–1.2M)

Finance reads FOH from ISM; S/4 remains settlement authority; the aging report with a named Finance owner is the real product.

Where this lands at Amazon. Every fulfillment event moves units before Finance posts them — the same window at a vastly larger grain. The transferable design: one real-time ledger, the financial system as settlement authority, a safe failure direction chosen before the happy path, and a control report with a named owner instead of a bridge spreadsheet. Reliability (over-sell zero by construction), cost efficiency (bridge labor and close time), one number for two organizations.

TWIST MAP — LIKELY LP QUESTIONS FROM THIS INTERVIEWER → THE ANGLE TO TAKE WITH S3

LIKELY QUESTION (THIS INTERVIEWER)	LP	ANGLE — WHAT TO EMPHASIZE	SKIP / NEVER SAY
Tell me about a time you got Finance and Operations to agree.	Earn Trust	FOH 2 → 1; the aging report given to Finance to own; signed inside the FSD on 6/5/25.	Never claim a pre-state drift dollar — the ≈$0.6M is modeled.
Tell me about a problem that needed you to understand the data at its grain.	Dive Deep	One posting per aggregate vs transaction lines; the Aggregation# ↔ header ↔ lines join; COGS pro-rated to the cent.	Skip the table names unless asked.
Tell me about simplifying something complex.	Invent and Simplify	One ledger, one settlement authority, one failure direction, one control report — instead of two books and a bridge.	Do not say "I built the matcher" — engineers implemented the design.

LIKELY QUESTION (THIS INTERVIEWER)	LP	ANGLE — WHAT TO EMPHASIZE	SKIP / NEVER SAY
How do you design controls for a process?	Functional — control design	Choose the failure direction first; a never-negative assertion; a KPI with a denominator (match rate ≥ 99.5% in 24 h); an aging report with a named owner; rollback that is cheap because the authority never moved.	Keep S14's standing reconciliation report out — bar raiser's.
What did you refuse and why?	Have Backbone	Per-line posting to S/4; a Finance-derived SNB — both refused on mechanism, not preference.	—
What would you do differently?	Learn and Be Curious	Internal Audit in discovery, not review.	No days-to-tie figure exists — do not invent one.

Question bank — likely questions for this interviewer, with a one-line answer plan

Behavioral and functional questions a peer Senior Manager of Supply Chain is likely to ask. Each plan points at a packet story or a bench story at the end of this packet (S4, S5, S9); stories allocated to other interviewers are pointers only.

#	LIKELY QUESTION	ANSWER PLAN (ONE LINE)	STORY
1	**Tell me about a time you aligned multiple organizations on one definition.**	S1 pitch — three truths, one signed FSD 6/5/25; pre-wiring; objections as rows; oversells recurring → zero.	S1
2	**Tell me about getting Finance to trust an operational number.**	S3 pitch — one FOH; failure direction; the aging report given to Finance to own.	S3
3	**How do you influence without authority?**	Pre-wire every row with its owner's LOE; working sessions to one table; three decisions not a review; a no that lives in a document. (S5, the council pack — same program; pointer only.)	S1 (S5 pointer)
4	**Tell me about a time you were wrong.**	S4 (bench) — the in-transit rule I wrote too conservatively; starved dotcom of fast movers; fixed through the same three signatories with a per-lane promise window and a kill switch; lesson: both sides of a rule get a number. Keep it to the pointer unless the room asks for the full walk.	S4 pointer
5	**How would our two teams share a process / a metric here?**	One definition with one owner per bucket; policy signed before code; a daily drift report with tolerance zero and a named control owner; a monthly release train for rule changes.	S1 / S3
6	**Tell me about designing for failure.**	S3 — the failure direction before the happy path; unmatched ⇒ under-sell; aging report at T+1.	S3
7	**How do you handle a stakeholder who wants a number that looks better (or a capability that sells more)?**	S1 — merch reserve promisable, priced as unpickable stock sold; visibility offered, promisability refused, written as a row.	S1
8	**How do you decompose a cross-functional process problem?**	Master §3.99 — book of record and metric first; stocks (every bucket a unit can sit in); flows with their documents; the broken invariant (a unit in two stocks; a number with two owners); minimal design; sequence.	Master §3.99
9	**What is the business value of the book-of-record migration?**	≈$2.5M/yr: $1M measured MCS run cost (anchor) + ≈$1.5M modeled with its three rows; incidents to zero is the record movement.	S1
10	**How do you keep a design from being re-litigated after sign-off?**	Three signatories, each owning a different truth; the out-of-scope fence (S5, bench); every change rides the monthly release train as an FSD change, not a side configuration (S4 pointer).	S1 (S5/S4 pointers)
11	**Tell me about a release / change-management discipline you set up.**	Rule changes ride the monthly cadence as signed FSD changes; the node × channel × bucket matrix is the regression gate; no story enters QA without a matrix cell reference.	S1
12	**What's one thing a peer would say is hard about working with you?**	I convert verbal agreements into rows people have to sign — slower in the week, faster over the program. Say it plainly, with the S1 pre-wiring as the example.	S1

Cheat-numbers box — canon values with basis labels

Canon numbers for S1 and S3 (and the S4/S5 bench stories) with their basis labels, from the master packet's §4.1 ledger.

METRIC	VALUE TO SAY	BASIS	NEVER
S1 primary metric	customer-facing oversell incidents recurring across three node types → zero through two go-lives	record	an oversell count or rate as record
S1 headline $	≈$2.5M/yr = $1M MCS run cost retired + ≈$1.5M modeled (oversell ≈$0.9M · recon ≈$0.33M · change premium ≈$0.3M); range $1.7–5.2M	user anchor + modeled	presenting the $1.5M as record; adding the shrink/time-to-market upside into the headline
S1 signatures / dates	FSD v1.1 (3/5/25) → v1.2 (5/16/25) → signed 6/5/25 by Supply Chain Strategy, Inventory Management, FSC Inventory Accounting	record	one signatory
S1 gate chain	kickoff 3/29 → council 5/15 → LOE 7/2 → sign-off 7/31 → FSD 8/14; E2E 11/22 · 12/20 · 1/30; January planning + May execution go-lives; 836 rows / 85.4% closed	record (shared program artifacts with S2/S5)	—
S1 design	lower-of-two basis; AFS = Basis − PickRes − EcomPick − EcomPack − SNB; idempotency key per event; daily ISM-vs-MB52 drift, tolerance 0; OMS reads, never computes	record design	"I configured S/4" / "I wrote ABAP"
S1 reconciliation FTE	≈4 FTE by hand → ≈1 FTE reading the drift report	modeled	stating it as record
S3 primary metric	Financial On-Hand truths 2 → 1; AFS decremented at sale/ship, not posting; over-sell from unmatched postings = 0 by construction	record (FSD 6/5/25)	—
S3 dollars	≈$0.6M/yr (cancels 0.45 · recon labor 0.14 · close 0.05); range $0.25–1.2M	modeled — no pre-state drift dollar in record	any record drift dollar; double-counting the cancel rate with S1
S3 design KPI	match rate ≥ 99.5% within 24 h; aging report empty or explained at T+1; Σ per-line COGS = posting COGS to the cent	record design	a days-to-tie figure
S4 (bench)	starved lanes → restored; oversell +0; kill switch never fired; ≈$0.5M/yr modeled margin	record / modeled	a dollar for the conversion lost while I was wrong
S5 (bench)	surprise escalations → 0; ~80 names across ~15 functions; 5/15 → 7/31 → 8/14; ≈$0.5M one-time modeled	record / modeled	—
SAP tenure	S/4HANA integration program lead 3+ years (Apr 2023 – present); client-SAP data integration at Elementum 2017–19; 15 years full-lifecycle SCM systems	record	"10 years of SAP configuration"; "SAP functional owner"

Never-say, one glance before the call.

- Never "I configured S/4," "I deploy SAP," or "I wrote ABAP" — integration program lead; SAP teams and configurators built to the signed FSD. Manhattan DOM is the only platform personally configured in canon.
- Never present the ≈$1.5M (S1) or the ≈$0.6M (S3) as record; the $1M MCS figure is the user anchor and the only measured dollar here.
- Never give the S1 and S3 cancel rates as two results in one room — keep S1's, drop S3's row.
- Never invent a days-to-tie figure, a direct-report headcount, or a pre-state oversell dollar.
- S4 and S5 are bench stories (full entries at the end of this packet) — reach for them only when the question does not fit S1/S3; one or two sentences in the question bank otherwise, then back to S1/S3.
- S14 (Earn Trust primary) is the bar raiser's; S2 (same umbrella program) is Goforth's — "one umbrella program" if asked, no floor story here.

Backup bench — use only if a primary doesn't fit

Three fallbacks for a peer Senior Manager — S4 and S5 are the question bank's pointers, here in full bench form: S4 (Sephora — the in-transit promise rule I got wrong, fixed through the same three signatories; the failure / Are Right, A Lot question), S5 (Sephora — the architecture council without owning a system; Backbone and influence without authority — same program family as S1, so use only when the question is about governance rather than the definition) and S9 (Elementum — the 597-lane Pareto two levels up; Backbone / Think Big outside the Sephora program). Tell S1 and S3 first.

Bench discipline. The two (or four) primaries above are the stories to tell first. Reach for a bench story only when the question genuinely does not fit a primary, or when the interviewer asks for "another example" on an LP already spent. Each entry is a 60-second pitch, a compressed STAR, one results line and two probes — enough to answer and stop; no full probing bank or derivation. Where a bench story is another interviewer's primary, the red note says so: use it only if the question demands it, and keep the facts identical to that packet.

BACKUP — ONLY IF ASKED S4 — Sephora S/4HANA — the in-transit promise rule I got wrong, fixed through the signed policy, not a side configuration

LPs this backup can serve: Are Right, A Lot (the failure question) · Customer Obsession (backup) · Earn Trust (owning the miss) · Learn and Be Curious — the designated policy-failure story

Basis. The v1 rule was mine; the indictment came from my own program's reports. Lane σ ≈ 0.3 day and the ~0.49-day window are the record's promise math; the record carries no lane counts and no dollar for the conversion lost while I was wrong — I will not invent the loss figure.

60-SECOND PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. My first ISM ruleset barred every channel from promising units in transit; the Aging In-Transit report showed dotcom starved of fast movers one day from the building. **Task.** Correct my own policy without weakening oversell protection, through the same three signatories. **Action.** Discovery: conversion-loss evidence from the aging and replenishment reports — the entry bar to reopen the policy; I stated that the v1 rule was mine. Plan & Design: promise math — lane σ ≈ 0.3 day, a ~0.49-day window ≈ 95% coverage; Promisable = in-transit × 1[ETA ≤ window] × 1[on-time ≥ floor]; Aging In-Transit as the kill switch; both blanket options rejected in writing. Build & Test: back-test against receiving history; four regression cells added to the node × channel matrix. Cutover: released on the normal monthly cadence as a signed FSD change, lane by lane — no hotfix, no side configuration. Hypercare: kill switch armed; never fired. Lesson: both sides of a rule get a number before it ships. **Result.** Primary metric: sellable units on qualifying in-transit lanes — starved → restored inside a per-lane promise window, oversell increase = zero, kill switch never fired. ≈$0.5M/yr modeled margin recovered — the record has no dollar for the conversion lost while I was wrong, and I will not invent one.

COMPRESSED STAR

- **S —** v1 of my own ISM ruleset: no channel could promise in-transit units — safe-feeling, and starving dotcom of fast movers reliably one day from the building.
- **T —** Fix my own signed policy without weakening oversell protection; take the miss back through the same three signatories.
- **A —** Evidence pack from Aging In-Transit and Replenishment; reframed as promise math (σ ≈ 0.3 d → ~0.49-d window ≈ 95%); rule with on-time floor and kill switch; back-test against receiving history; four regression cells; released lane by lane on the monthly cadence as an FSD change.

- **R —** Starved lanes restored inside the window; oversell increase = 0; kill switch never fired; re-signed by the same three signatories; lesson institutionalized — the Locus 98% gate (S2) and the 0.5% tolerance (S18) were set from data before the event.

RESULTS LINE

Sellable units on qualifying in-transit lanes starved → restored inside a back-tested ~0.49-day window (record) · oversell increase = 0; kill switch armed, never fired (record) · four regression cells added (record) · released as a signed FSD change on the normal cadence, no hotfix (record) · ≈$0.5M/yr modeled margin recovered (inputs illustrative).

TWO PROBES

> **Why not just hotfix it — you knew it was wrong?**
>
> Because the error was in the policy, so the fix had to be too — in the governed artifact, with regression, through the same signatures. A side configuration would have fixed the symptom and left the policy lying about what it allowed.

> **What did the miss cost?**
>
> The record carries no dollar for the conversion lost while v1 stood, and I will not invent one. What I can say is the mechanism: fast movers reliably one day from the building were unsellable on dotcom until the window existed; the ≈$0.5M/yr recovered is my model on illustrative inputs, labeled.

Canon numbers (basis labels): Lane σ ≈ 0.3 d; ~0.49-d window ≈ 95% coverage (record promise math) · oversell increase = 0 (record) · 4 regression cells (record) · kill switch never fired (record) · same three signatories re-signed (record) · ≈$0.5M/yr (modeled). Never a lane count; never a dollar for the loss while wrong.

BACKUP — ONLY IF ASKED S5 — Sephora — the architecture council without owning any system: three decisions and a fence

LPs this backup can serve: Have Backbone; Disagree & Commit (third) · Earn Trust (influence without authority) · Think Big (architecture governance). Same program family as S1/S2 — the governance story

Basis. I owned none of the systems; the design decision was the deliverable. Zero escalations and the dated gate chain are the record; the dollars are my model of what governance avoided.

60-SECOND PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. The UDC location and inventory model had to clear architecture council — a challenge gate — with ~80 named participants across ~15 functions, and I owned none of those systems. **Task.** Take the design from discovery through council to sign-off and FSD without a surprise escalation. **Action.** Discovery: both inventory books profiled before any design argument; business sessions closed 4/30. Plan & Design: every impacted row pre-wired with a signed LOE by 7/2; the council asked for three separable decisions plus an out-of-scope fence (reserve math untouched; MCS decommission belongs to Global ERP). Build & Test: the "build" was the pack — architecture, staged timeline, peak-freeze boundary. Cutover: 5/15 challenge → 7/31 sign-off → 8/14 FSD. Hypercare: the fence held in writing for the whole program; a second live warehouse became a monitored shadow copy, not an argument. Lesson: a no that lives in a document survives. **Result.** Primary metric: surprise escalations on a 60+ stakeholder design — the norm on prior programs → zero; the dated gate chain held. ≈$0.5M one-time modeled (avoided rework on ~3 escalations that never happened + six weeks of benefit not deferred + a fenced second reserve engine not built).

COMPRESSED STAR

- **S —** A dozen core systems (20+ touched), ~80 participants across ~15 functions, a council that re-litigates designs this size — and I owned none of the systems.
- **T —** Discovery (kickoff 3/29, sessions 4/30) → council 5/15 → sign-off 7/31 → FSD 8/14, without a surprise escalation.
- **A —** Profiled both books first — their numbers, not my opinion; systems-impacted table with an owner on every row; one LOE template, one deadline (7/2), one private conversation per owner before the room; three separable decisions plus the fence; the second-truth objection converted into a monitored shadow copy.
- **R —** Surprise escalations → 0 for the program's life; 100% pre-wire coverage by 7/2; gate chain held to the day with zero re-litigation; fence breaches 0; handed clean into the build (S2).

RESULTS LINE

Surprise escalations → 0 for the program's life (record) · gate chain 3/29 → 4/30 → 5/15 → 7/2 → 7/31 → 8/14 held to the day (record) · pre-wire coverage 100% — every impacted row with a signed LOE by 7/2 (record) · both scope refusals held in writing; fence breaches 0 (record) · ≈$0.5M one-time (modeled — what did not happen).

TWO PROBES

How do you get sixty people to sign LOE you don't control?

A template, a deadline and a private conversation each — so nobody learned their cost in the room. The council was then asked for three separable decisions it could take one at a time; separability was the design.

What did you refuse, and did it hold?

Retuning the reserve math and folding in the MCS decommission — both written, signed and held; later scope requests were answered from the pack in writing. The legitimate concern (a second live warehouse becoming a second truth) was converted into the design as a monitored shadow copy, because converting a concern costs less than winning it.

Canon numbers (basis labels): ~80 participants / ~15 functions; a dozen core systems, 20+ touched (record) · 5/15 → 7/31 → 8/14; LOE 7/2 (record dates) · escalations 0; fence breaches 0 (record) · ≈$0.5M one-time (modeled). Never a dollar as record; never pair with S1 or S2 for the same interviewer.

BACKUP — ONLY IF ASKED S9 — Elementum — 1,000 supplier/carrier routes asked, 597 built first: X12 EDI onboarding behind a ≥95% valid-ASN cohort gate

LPs this backup can serve: Have Backbone; Disagree & Commit (primary — 597 vs 1,000, two levels up) · Deliver Results · Insist on the Highest Standards (the gate held twice) · Think Big (the staged 1,000-lane vision) · Broad Responsibility (small carriers kept inside the standard by the portal floor)

Basis. I owned the scope analysis and the onboarding standard, influencing an executive two levels above my sponsor; engineers built the maps and harness to the standard; Transportation owned the carrier relationships. Cohort sizes and the number of cohorts are not in the record — do not quote them.

60-SECOND PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. The Global Head of Supply Chain wanted inbound visibility on 1,000 lanes in two months; shipment-data completeness was 60% and high-value lanes were blind. **Task.** I owned the scope analysis and the onboarding standard, influencing an executive two levels above my sponsor. **Action.** Discovery: a spend Pareto — 597 lanes carried 80% of freight spend — pre-validated with Transportation and Procurement before I took it up. Plan & Design: the onboarding standard (X12 850/855/856/940/945/214/997 with an XML/portal floor — "the standard was the data, not the transport") and a cohort gate of ≥95% valid ASN. Build & Test: a mapping-and-test harness and a scorecard per lane. Cutover: 597 live in month one; one cohort failed the gate twice on a timestamp format and I held it both times. Hypercare: completeness scorecards to 95%; ~200 lanes the next wave behind the same gate. Lesson: automating dirty data manufactures confident wrong answers — the gate is the product. **Result.** Primary metric: inbound shipment-data completeness 60% → 95%. Freight spend −10% ≈ $2M in six months (record); 597 lanes = 80% of spend live in month one; adoption 8×.

COMPRESSED STAR

- **S —** 1,000 global lanes asked in two months — scope, schedule and quality all fixed; completeness 60%; lanes differed by orders of magnitude in spend and carriers differed in EDI capability.
- **T —** Own the scope analysis and the onboarding standard; take the re-scope two levels up with the evidence attached.
- **A —** Spend Pareto (597 = 80% of spend) pre-validated so no lane owner could contradict it in the room; standard + ≥95% valid-ASN gate published to carriers before cohort one; harness so later cohorts were mostly configuration; held a failing cohort twice; ~400 lanes carrying ~20% of spend deferred — priced in spend share, not lane count.
- **R —** Completeness 60 → 95%; 100% visibility on high-value lanes; 597 lanes live month one; freight −10% ≈ $2M in six months (record); method written up as the sourcing SOP.

RESULTS LINE

Completeness 60% → 95% (record) · 597 of 1,000 lanes = 80% of freight spend live in month one (record) · freight spend −10% ≈ $2M in six months (record — kept as measured, never annualized) · adoption 8× (record) · ≈$0.4M/yr document-handling labor (modeled add-on).

TWO PROBES

You defied a Global Head of Supply Chain's number. How?

With the spend curve and the lane owners' validation attached — 597 lanes carried 80% of the spend, so the phased plan was argued in spend share, not lane count. He accepted the phasing off the curve; I then committed to the remainder behind the same gate and delivered it.

> **Is the $2M annualized?**
>
> No — it is the record as measured: minus ten percent on the onboarded lanes' spend in six months. My three-way split (routing-guide compliance ~$0.8M, mode discipline ~$0.6M, expedites and detention ~$0.6M) decomposes the record; it never adds to it.

Canon numbers (basis labels): 60% → 95% completeness (record) · 597 / 1,000 lanes = 80% of spend (record) · −10% ≈ $2M in 6 months (record) · ≥95% valid-ASN gate, held twice (record) · 8× adoption (record) · ≈$0.4M/yr labor (modeled). Never: cohort counts or sizes; never double the $2M into a run-rate.